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FREE PLAYBOOK

ROAS Lies.
Profit Doesn't.

The Real Profit Playbook for 7-Figure Shopify Operators

7 Frameworks to Fix Your Foundation Before You Scale

By Brian Lasonde | PPC Boost

20+ years managing paid media, tested on accounts spending $2K–$500K/month

400%

ROAS — MOD LIGHTING SCALE-UP

200%+

PROFIT INCREASE — HOME LABS RESTRUCTURE

90%

CPL REDUCTION — PANDORA CLOUDCOVER

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> **This playbook is distilled from the Ad Stack Weekly newsletter and 20+ years of managing paid media for Shopify brands. Every framework here has been tested on real accounts spending $2K–$500K/month.**

MOD LIGHTING

PANDORA CLOUDCOVER

RECYCLE AWAY

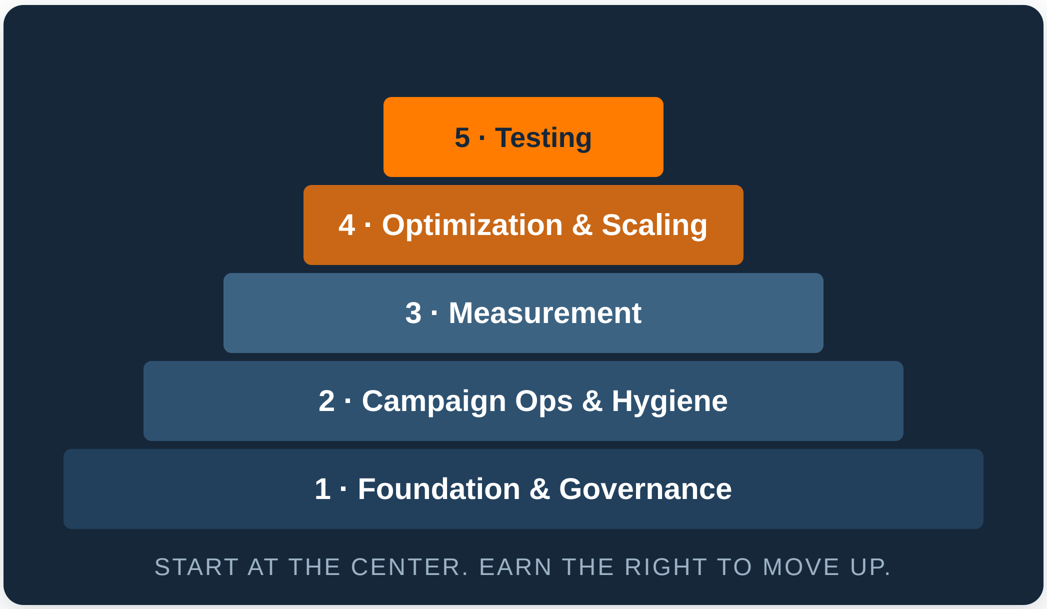
K2 SCIENTIFIC

MANLY BANDS

CHAPTER 1

The 5 Layers of Google Ads Excellence

Most advertisers try to scale before they've built anything worth scaling. They chase new campaign types, fancy tests, and growth hacks while their foundation quietly leaks budget underneath them.



Great Google Ads accounts are built in five layers, and you can't skip one to reach the next. Think of it like a target: start at the center and earn the right to move outward.

1. Foundation & Governance. Business goals, conversion goals, budget guardrails, naming standards, brand vs. non-brand separation. Get this wrong and nothing above it works.

2. Campaign Ops & Hygiene. Settings, policy status, spend pacing, negative keyword lists, landing-page checks. The boring stuff that protects your spend every single day.

3. Measurement. CPA and ROAS trends, attribution checks, impression share, search-term quality. You can't optimize what you can't see.

4. Optimization & Scaling. Query expansion, creative refresh, budget reallocation, Performance Max experiments. Now — and only now — you push.

5. Testing & Expansion. Geo tests, Smart Bidding targets, Demand Gen, YouTube. Controlled bets on a system that already works.

> **Bring this to your next account review: which layer is your account actually operating from? Most teams run Layer 4 tactics on a Layer 2 foundation. Start at the center and earn the right to move outward.**

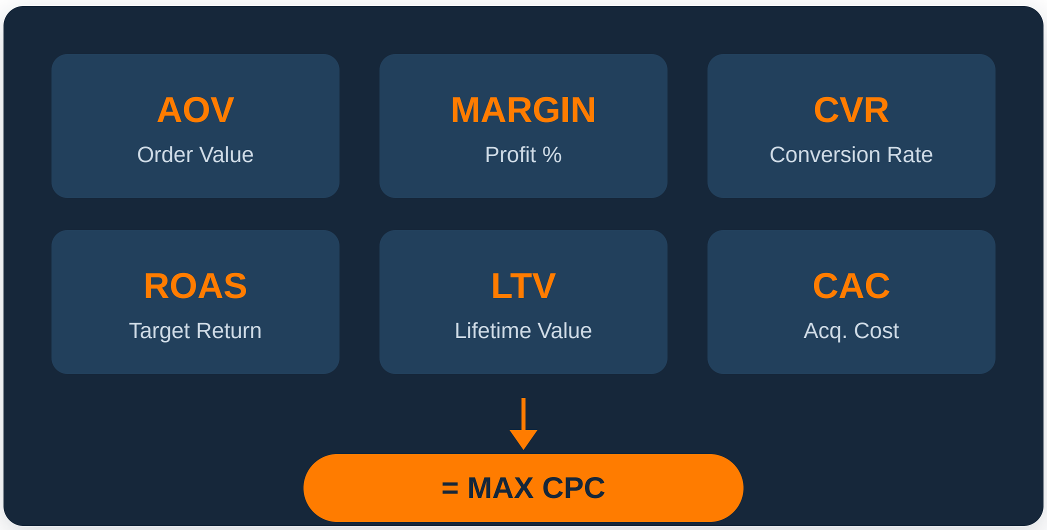
📡 **INDUSTRY SIGNAL**

Google Ads now lets you set a single reach or frequency goal across multiple video campaigns globally. A Meridian study found that an optimal frequency of 2.7 impressions per week drove a 19% ROI lift — proof that disciplined measurement (Layer 3) directly funds smarter scaling (Layer 4).

CHAPTER 2

Know Your Max CPC — The Math That Replaces Guesswork

Too many advertisers set bids based on competitor activity, Google's bid suggestions, or what "feels right." They raise bids when campaigns feel slow and cut bids when spend feels scary — and only realize they're losing money when the credit card statement arrives.



There's a better way. You need six numbers to know exactly the highest cost-per-click you can afford to pay before a single click becomes unprofitable.

The 6-Number Formula

- **Average Order Value (AOV)** — what a typical customer spends per transaction.
- **Profit Margin** — the percentage you actually keep after COGS.
- **Conversion Rate** — what percentage of clicks turn into purchases.
- **Target ROAS or MER** — the return threshold that keeps you profitable.
- **Customer Lifetime Value (LTV)** — the total revenue a customer generates over time.

- **Acceptable Acquisition Cost** — the most you can spend to acquire one customer.

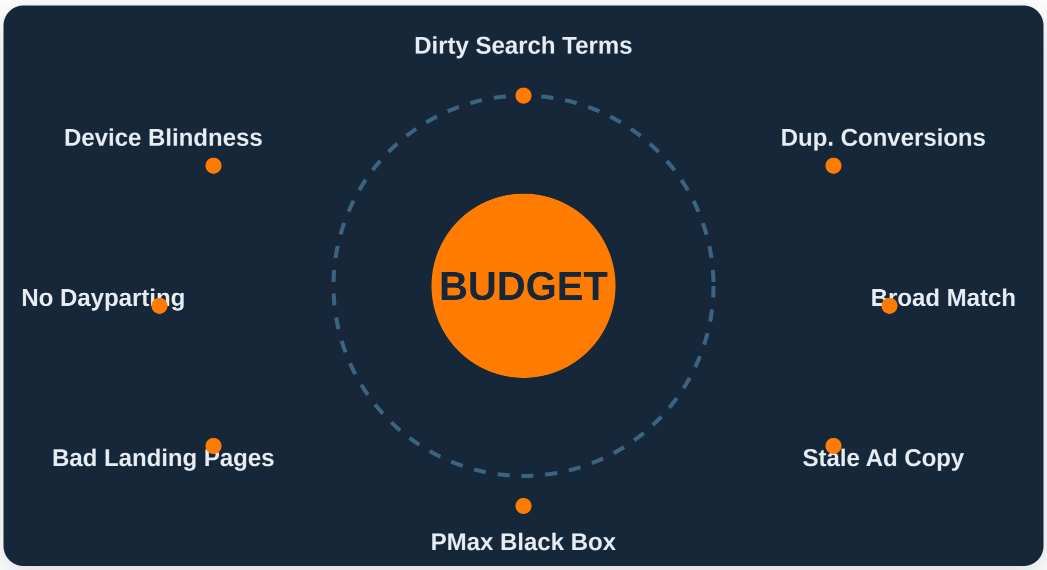
Once you have these, the math is straightforward: your Max CPC equals your Acceptable Acquisition Cost multiplied by your Conversion Rate. If your target CPA is $50 and your conversion rate is 2%, your max CPC is $1.00. Bid above that and you're losing money on every click.

> **Stop guessing. Run this formula on your top 10 campaigns this week. If your actual CPC is higher than your max CPC, you're paying for clicks you can't afford — and no amount of optimization will fix that.**

CHAPTER 3

8 Budget Leaks Draining Your Account Right Now

Most PPC teams don't struggle because they lack effort. They struggle because small operational gaps compound into serious budget waste.



Here are the eight most common leaks we find when auditing accounts — and how to fix each one.

1. Dirty Search Terms. You're paying for irrelevant queries because you haven't reviewed your search terms report in weeks. Negative keyword lists are your first line of defense.

2. Duplicate Conversions. Tracking the same conversion multiple times inflates your reported ROAS and feeds bad data into Smart Bidding. Audit your conversion actions quarterly.

3. Broad Match Without Guardrails. Broad match can work, but only with a strong negative keyword list and tight audience signals. Without those, you're funding Google's guesswork.

4. Stale Ad Copy. Ads that haven't been refreshed in months lose click-through rate and quality score. A lower quality score means you pay more per click for the same position.

5. Performance Max Black Box. PMax can cannibalize your brand traffic and attribute it as new demand. Segment brand from non-brand to see where revenue is actually coming from.

6. Misaligned Landing Pages. Your ad promises one thing and your landing page delivers another. Every mismatch tanks conversion rate and bleeds budget.

7. No Dayparting or Geo Exclusions. Running ads 24/7 everywhere when your best customers buy at specific times and places is pure waste.

8. Ignoring Device Performance. Mobile and desktop convert at vastly different rates. If you're not adjusting bids by device, you're overpaying somewhere.

> 📡 **INDUSTRY SIGNAL**
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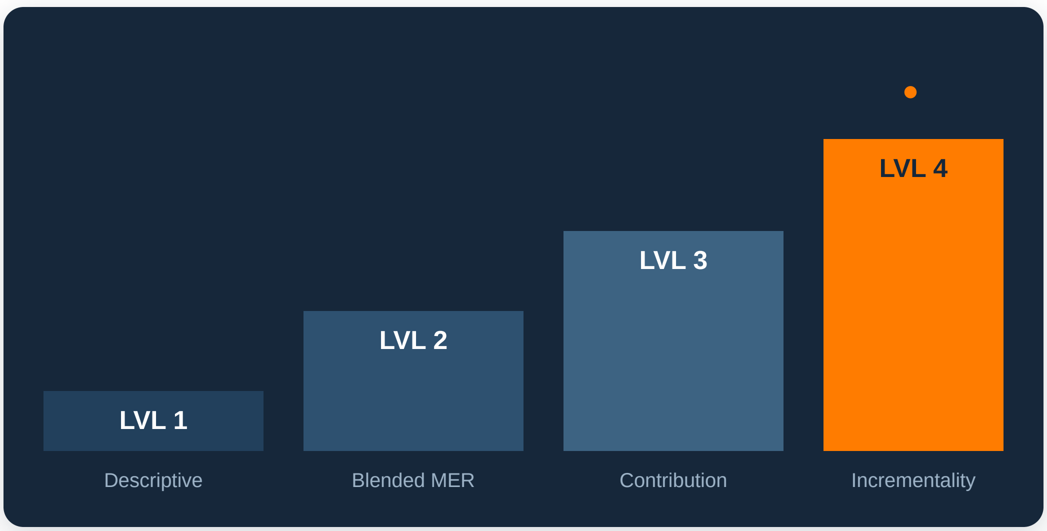
> Research shows that cutting paid social often erodes search performance 4–8 weeks later, because social creates the brand demand that search harvests. Before shifting budget between channels, measure with brand query volume, cohort CVR, or geo holdouts — not just last-click ROAS.

CHAPTER 4

Platform ROAS Is Lying to You: What to Measure Instead

The metric most Shopify brands trust the most is the one getting them in trouble. Platform ROAS — the number Google and Meta report back to you — is calculated as revenue divided by ad spend. It sounds simple, but it's deeply misleading.



Why Platform ROAS Breaks Down

- Both platforms take credit for conversions they didn't cause — especially with broad attribution windows.
- Google and Meta often double-count the same purchase if a customer saw ads on both platforms.
- ROAS measures revenue, not profit. A 5x ROAS on a 20% margin product means you barely broke even after ad spend.

The 4 Analytics Layers Most Advertisers Skip

We walk every new client through four levels of measurement maturity — and most are stuck at Level 1.

1. **Descriptive (Level 1).** Impressions, clicks, spend, conversions. What happened. This is where most brands live.

2. **Blended ROAS / MER (Level 2).** Total revenue ÷ total media spend. One number, no attribution games. A massive improvement.

3. **Contribution Margin Analysis (Level 3).** Subtract COGS, shipping, returns, and ad spend from revenue to see true profit per order. This is what sophisticated ecommerce owners use.

4. **Incrementality Testing (Level 4).** Geo holdouts, matched-market tests, and lift studies that prove whether your ads actually caused the sale. The gold standard.

> **If you're making budget decisions based on platform ROAS alone, you're flying blind. Start with MER this week — it takes five minutes to calculate and it will change how you think about every dollar you spend.**

CHAPTER 5

Stop Asking "Google or Facebook?" — Ask This Instead

"Should I run Google Ads or Facebook Ads?" is the wrong question. Both platforms serve fundamentally different roles in your customer's buying journey, and the answer is almost always "both — but differently."

The Real Question: Where Is Your Customer in the Buying Cycle?

Google captures existing demand. Someone searches "modern pendant lights under $200" — they already want what you sell. Your job is to show up with the right ad and the right landing page.

Meta creates new demand. Someone is scrolling Instagram and sees a video of your pendant light in a beautifully styled kitchen. They didn't know they wanted it until that moment. Your job is to create the desire with creative.

Creative Is the New Targeting

Interest-based targeting on Meta is effectively dead. The algorithm ignores most interest selections and finds buyers based on behavior signals and engagement patterns. That means **your creative IS your targeting.** If you want to reach new parents, your ad needs to show a nursery — not your audience settings.

This is the single biggest shift in performance marketing over the past two years, and most brands haven't caught up. They're still running the same static ads they launched six months ago and wondering why CPAs keep climbing.

> **Rule of thumb: allocate roughly 10% of your media spend toward creative production. If you're spending $50K/month on ads and $0 on creative, you're asking the engine to run without fuel.**

📡 INDUSTRY SIGNAL

An ICSC survey found that 70% of consumers have abandoned a purchase over shipping costs and 67% say return fees make them less likely to buy online — another reason your creative and landing page experience need to address objections before the checkout page.

CHAPTER 6

The 8 Fundamentals Before You Scale Spend

Before you increase your ad budget, make sure these eight foundations are locked in. Scaling on a broken foundation doesn't grow your business — it just burns money faster.

1. **Conversion Tracking Is Clean.** Every conversion action is deduplicated, properly attributed, and firing on the right events. No vanity conversions inflating your data.

2. **Your Unit Economics Are Clear.** You know your AOV, profit margin, acceptable CPA, and LTV. You can answer: "What's the most I can pay for a customer and still make money?"

3. **Account Structure Matches Intent.** Brand and non-brand are separated. Campaign types are chosen based on funnel stage, not convenience.

4. **Negative Keywords Are Active.** Shared negative keyword lists are reviewed weekly. Irrelevant queries are caught before they drain budget.

5. **Landing Pages Are Aligned.** The promise in your ad matches the experience on your page. Mobile load time is under 3 seconds.

6. **Bidding Strategy Fits the Data.** You have enough conversion volume for Smart Bidding (30+ per month per campaign). If not, manual or enhanced CPC until you get there.

7. **Creative Is Fresh.** Ads updated in the last 60 days. At least 2–3 variations per ad group. On Meta, new creative is shipping regularly.

8. **Reporting Tells a Story.** You're tracking trends, comparing periods, and connecting ad performance to actual business profitability.

Score yourself: how many of these 8 are genuinely locked in for your account? If the answer is fewer than 6, scaling spend will only amplify the gaps.

CHAPTER 7

Real Brands, Real Numbers: 3 Case Studies

Frameworks are only useful if they produce results. Here are three brands that applied the principles in this playbook — and the numbers they generated.

MOD Lighting — $9M+ Revenue at 400% ROAS

MOD Lighting sells modern, affordable chandeliers and lighting products. The founder was managing campaigns himself while handling inventory, product development, and customer service.

When PPC Boost took over, the first step was restructuring the account around the 5-layer framework: clean conversion tracking, proper campaign segmentation, and measurement that connected ad spend to profitability. Shopping and Performance Max structure was rebuilt across Google and Bing; product titles were optimized in the feed to match how buyers actually search.

The result: **$9M+ in top-line revenue in the first year and a half, with ROAS consistently above 400%.** The founder shifted to developing new product lines, hiring an internal team, and working with manufacturing partners overseas.

> ★★★★★
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> *"PPC Boost has been instrumental in scaling our Google and Facebook ad accounts. We were able to hit $9MM in topline revenue in our first year in business with ROAS over 400%. Their level of experience with high spending Google & Facebook accounts is hard to find."*
>
> **Henry Liu — CEO, MOD Lighting**

Pandora CloudCover — 90% CPL Reduction, 600% More High-Value Leads

Pandora CloudCover provides streaming music services for businesses — a B2B play with a long sales cycle and a specific ideal customer: multi-location operators.

The work started with Chapter 3: fixing the leaks. The search terms report was full of irrelevant queries draining budget. Negatives went in, converting terms got promoted to keywords, tCPA bidding took over where it made sense, and tighter ad copy lifted CTRs.

The headline numbers: **110% lead increase, 90% CPL drop.** But the number that mattered most was a **600% jump in multi-location leads** — the exact high-value customers Pandora was after.

Home Labs — 200%+ Profit Increase

Home Labs came to PPC Boost struggling with profitability despite healthy revenue. The team's approach was to zoom out from platform metrics and focus on real business profitability — the exact shift described in Chapter 4.

By restructuring campaigns to prioritize profitable products over high-revenue products, cleaning up wasted spend, and implementing proper measurement, the team **increased Google Ads budget and performance while boosting overall profit by over 200%.**

> **Every one of these results started with the same move: fixing the foundation before trying to scale. The frameworks in this playbook aren't theory — they're the exact process behind these numbers.**

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WHAT'S NEXT

Ready to Fix Your Foundation?

This playbook gives you the frameworks. But frameworks without execution are just ideas on a page.

If you're a Shopify brand doing **$1M–$10M+** in annual revenue and spending **$2K or more per month** on Google or Meta ads, we should talk.

PPC Boost is a boutique paid-media agency that focuses exclusively on Google Ads and Meta Ads. No SEO upsells, no email marketing packages — just senior account managers who've managed $1M+/month in spend and have worked together for over seven years.

What You Get on the First Call

- A 30-minute discovery session to understand your goals, metrics, and current account health.
- A full account audit (we'll request read-only access on the call).
- An honest assessment of where your account sits on the 5-layer framework — and what to fix first.

Book a free strategy call at ppcboost.com

And if you're not ready for a call yet, subscribe to **Ad Stack Weekly** — Brian's free weekly newsletter covering the latest in Google Ads, Meta Ads, and ecommerce growth.

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Brian Lasonde

Founder, PPC Boost | 20+ years in performance marketing

From building websites on Angelfire to scaling Shopify brands past $10M.